

Animal Welfare Policy

Protecting the welfare of animals involved in our provision

15-17 Irlam Road, Bootle, Liverpool, L20 4AE · Alternative Provision for Ages 5–25

ADOPTED POLICY

This policy has been formally adopted by L-Fit Pathways' co-directors and is in effect from the date shown below. Any section still shown in [square brackets and amber text] is organisation-specific detail that remains to be confirmed and inserted - it does not affect the rest of the policy's validity but should be completed as soon as possible.

Version: 1.0 (Adopted)

Date Adopted: 16 September 2026

Next Review Due: 16 September 2027 (or sooner following any legislative change or relevant incident)

1. Statement of Intent

L-Fit Pathways is committed to the welfare of any animal involved in our Animal Assisted Learning provision, in line with the Animal Welfare Act 2006. Good animal welfare and good safeguarding go hand in hand — an animal that is calm, healthy and well cared for is essential to safe, effective sessions.

2. Legal Framework

- Animal Welfare Act 2006 — the duty to ensure the five welfare needs of any animal in our care

[If applicable, confirm any local authority animal activity licence held (Animal Welfare (Licensing of Activities Involving Animals) (England) Regulations 2018)]

3. The Five Welfare Needs

- A suitable environment
- A suitable diet
- The ability to exhibit normal behaviour patterns
- Appropriate housing with, or apart from, other animals
- Protection from pain, suffering, injury and disease

4. Animal Care Standards

[Confirm which animals are used in AAL sessions, their housing arrangements, and who holds day-to-day responsibility for their care]

5. Handler Qualifications & Supervision

All Animal Assisted Learning sessions are led by a trained handler who is responsible for reading the animal's welfare and behaviour throughout the session, and for pausing or ending a session if the animal shows signs of stress.

[Confirm handler name(s) and relevant qualifications/experience]

6. Interaction Rules

- Young people are briefed on safe, respectful handling before any contact with an animal
- Sessions are structured to give the animal regular rest periods away from young people
- Hand-washing and hygiene measures are followed before and after contact — see our Health & Safety Policy

7. Incident Procedure

Any incident involving an animal — whether an injury to a young person, a welfare concern, or unexpected animal behaviour — is recorded, reported to a Designated Safeguarding Lead, and reviewed to determine whether the animal, activity or environment needs to change before sessions resume.

8. Roles & Responsibilities

The Co-Directors hold overall responsibility for the welfare of any animal used in L-Fit Pathways provision, supported by the trained handler(s) delivering each session.

9. Monitoring & Review

This policy is reviewed annually, or sooner following an animal welfare or safety incident.

Policy adopted on: 16 September 2026 — Next review due: 16 September 2027